

PRIVATE CIRCULATION.

PRIMROSE HILL PARK,

REGENT'S PARK,

AND

HAMPSTEAD HEATH.

LONDON:
PRINTED BY SHAW AND SONS, FETTER LANE, E.C.
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HILL PARK, REGENT'S PARK, AND HAMPSTEAD HEATH ***

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PREFACE.

THE main object sought to be attained in this correspondence was to induce the Government to purchase two plots of land adjoining Primrose Hill Park, together about eighteen acres, that space may be given to a great and rapidly-increasing population for football and cricket. It is probable most persons who know the wants of the district will be of opinion that it is very desirable this should be done. Every summer's evening there is, in the small space of ground now available in the Regent's Park, over-crowding and a badly made game. Many who wish to play cannot for want of room, and two fine boys, about fourteen years of age, complained that they were frequently hit, and the balls crossed each other so closely that they did not know their own ball. But another proposal was incidentally mentioned, upon which there cannot be the same unanimity. It is suggested that a road should be made from the top of Portland Place for equestrians, carriages, and cabs through the Regent's Park, and then to some part of Hampstead Heath. If any one considering this question will stand at the top of Portland Place and imagine the same carried on straight through the park, and then, as far as now can be done, a park-like road made to the Heath, and reflect how charming and healthy such a drive and ride must be, with the bracing air and beautiful views on all sides, easy and pleasant of access, he, perhaps, may think the scheme worthy of very careful investigation.

Those who are acquainted with Paris know the extraordinary change for the better effected when a new and direct road was carried from the Arc de L'Etoile to the Bois de Boulogne, and it is to be presumed that improvements will, without loss of time, be made in Hampstead Heath, and, as in the Bois de Boulogne, suitable rides and drives created. The natural advantages of the situation are in favour of London as compared with Paris, and it is not too much to say, if proper use is made of them, that, as a whole, Regent's Park, Primrose Hill Park, and Hampstead Heath will, for all the purposes that parks are formed, be unsurpassed in Europe.

But to open the park at Portland Place may require an Act of Parliament, and many may think the Regent's Park is best as it is; nevertheless, the extreme beauty of a road through the centre of the Regent's Park, in addition to being so much nearer, ought to be a consideration. It will shorten the drive to Primrose Hill going and returning, over the present route, nearly a mile; but should this not be deemed sufficient reason for the change, then it may be desirable to make a carriage bridge over the canal instead of the present foot bridge at the end of the Broad Walk, opening into the Albert Road at St. Mark's Church and close by Primrose Hill.

Should public opinion approve this scheme there is no reason to suppose the Government will offer any opposition to it.

2, ST. EDMUND'S TERRACE,
REGENT'S PARK NORTH,
25th June, 1873.

LETTERS.

The Right Hon. W. E. GLADSTONE, M.P.,
&c., &c.

SIR,

Knowing the great and arduous duties you have to perform I regret being obliged to call your attention to a very small affair, but the case is urgent, and in a few months buildings will be placed upon a portion of the ground.

Primrose Hill Park is very much used by boys as a cricket or foot-ball ground, and on Saturdays there is not enough space. Even to-day, with the ground wet and weather not inviting, it was full, and in the summer months boys go away because there is not room to play.

It may, therefore, be worthy of your consideration whether the Government should not purchase the Eton and Middlesex Cricket Ground, which adjoins, and consists of about twelve acres. This is a private ground, and, I believe, does not pay. There is another plot of about six acres which will be immediately built upon unless the Government at once secure it.

This would make a splendid addition to the park, and, perhaps, £20,000 would purchase the whole.

I have the honour to be, Sir,

Your obedient servant,
WILLIAM RAY SMEE.

Regent's Park North,
5th April, 1873.

WILLIAM RAY SMEE, Esq.,

SIR,

Mr. Gladstone desires me to acknowledge the receipt of your letter of the 6th instant.

I am, Sir,

Your obedient Servant,
J. A. GODLEY.

10, Downing Street, Whitehall,
8th April, 1873.

Right Hon. W. E. GLADSTONE, M.P.,
&c., &c.

SIR,

I am obliged to trouble you again respecting the purchase by the Government of about eighteen acres of land adjoining Primrose Hill Park, for upon a portion of it the turf is now being rapidly taken away, and the land is to be built upon unless something is at once decided.

There is a necessity for adding this ground to the Park. The population is rapidly increasing. Every small open space is closed. Boys and youths who cannot afford to pay have no place for cricket except on public property. On Saturdays, the young of more than half a million of people come to Primrose Hill, or would come if there were space. This afternoon there were between 2,000 and 3,000, and if the day had been finer there would have been many more.

I showed to a gentleman well conversant with the district the ground I thought ought to be purchased, and he assured me in five years' time, with the addition, space would be wanting, and strongly urged the publication of the suggestion. That, however, I am very unwilling to do so long as there is a prospect of the Government acting in this business, and I therefore venture respectfully to ask your decision.

Assume that the cost will be £20,000, it is only part of the interest on that amount the Government can lose. The State is equally rich whether the

property is in money or land. The eighteen acres will make excellent sheep land, and must yield something, and the strength and health given to many thousand youths must speedily add to the national revenue far more than the remainder.

The financial side of the question is really quite insignificant, but the moral good done will be of the highest importance.

I have the honour to be, Sir,

Your obedient Servant,
WILLIAM RAY SMEE.

Regent's Park North,
26th April, 1873.

Before this letter was answered the following was sent:—

Mr. WILLIAM RAY SMEE presents his respects to Mr. Gladstone, and, in reference to his communication of Saturday, wishes to say, as showing the importance of taking into consideration the rapid increase of population; that some years ago, when there was a field walk, but little frequented on weekdays, from Primrose Hill to Hampstead, he proposed to Lord Palmerston to purchase sufficient ground and make a road from the top of Portland Place, through Regent's Park, and round Primrose Hill straight to Hampstead Heath.

This road along its whole length was to have been Park-like, to be used by carriages, cabs, and persons on horseback, would have added to the beauty of the West of London, and if the Government had thought it desirable, might have been made to repay its cost by the surplus land between Primrose Hill and Hampstead that might have been sold for villas.

Such a road was much wanted, and private enterprise has already made two-thirds of it, and placed houses on both sides. Nevertheless it is altogether different from what the State would have done. It is neither broad nor straight. It does not add to, but takes from the beauty of the neighbourhood. In the meantime Hampstead Heath has become public property, and the opportunity to make a direct approach thereto from

Regent Street in a way, which foreign visitors to London would have greatly admired, is permanently lost.

Mr. Smee mentions this, as it may still be worthy of consideration, whether Regent's Park might not be opened at Portland Place, and whether anything can now be accomplished in the unmade portion of the road between Primrose Hill and Hampstead Heath.

To the Right Hon. W. E. Gladstone, M.P.,
&c., &c.,

Regent's Park North,
2nd May, 1873.

On the 6th May the letter of the 26th April was acknowledged:—

TO WILLIAM RAY SMEE, ESQ.,

SIR,

Mr. Gladstone desires me to acknowledge the receipt of your letter of the 2nd instant, on a matter which seems to belong to the province of the Metropolitan Board of Works.

I am, Sir,

Your obedient Servant,
J. A. GODLEY.

10, Downing Street,
8th May, 1873.

Right Hon. W. E. GLADSTONE, M.P.,

SIR,

I believe with this letter, I have done all that a gentleman in a private station can with propriety do to urge upon the Government the purchase of two plots of land, one of six acres and the other of twelve, adjoining Primrose Hill, to be used by boys and youths for foot-ball and cricket. In a very short

time buildings will be commenced upon the smaller plot, and the opportunity will be lost.

How much this ground is now wanted was apparent in the numbers playing cricket this afternoon in the Regent's Park. In the portion allotted to boys the wickets were placed in many cases only eight yards apart; perhaps there were 1000 boys playing, and only those clubs were allowed that previously had obtained permission.

The same applies to the ground for youths and men. There were, perhaps, 800 playing; one set of wickets was close to another on all sides, and it was marvellous the game could go on without serious accidents. A sergeant of police that happened to be passing told me it looked most dangerous, and nothing would induce him to join; but a youth, who was playing, said the accidents were very few,—although at first he was much frightened, yet the danger was not so great as it appeared.

The purchase of the eighteen acres would relieve this ground, enable some of the clubs to go to Primrose Hill, and cricket could be properly and joyfully played, and space would be given for many who now very much wish to play but cannot.

I have only to add, that should next Saturday afternoon prove fine, any gentleman, about five o'clock in the afternoon, may ascertain how painful to witness is the present over-crowded cricket ground of the Regent's Park.

I have the honour to be, Sir,

Your obedient Servant,
WILLIAM RAY SMEE.

Regent's Park North,
10th May, 1873.

WILLIAM RAY SMEE, ESQ.,

Sir,

Mr. Gladstone desires me to inform you that your letter of the 10th inst. should have been addressed to the First Commissioner of Works.

I am, Sir,

Your obedient Servant,
W. E. GURDON.

10, Downing Street,
15th May, 1873.

This closes the correspondence, and upon reflection it will be apparent that a great nation can find no better and no more economical use for a little mite of surplus revenue than its judicious employment in providing space for healthy, innocent, and cheap out-door amusement. The money so spent on behalf of the population of this gigantic capital will double itself over and over again. It is the active and the healthy that make a nation progress. It is good sound sense, united with a vigorous frame, that enables the man, advantageously to himself, to augment the receipts of the British exchequer.

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